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## World Health Organization (WHO) – Public Health Alert

# Unexplained Clusters of Severe Respiratory Illness in Australia

Event ID: **WHO-WPRO-Resp-2024-001**

Affected Region: **Queensland, Australia**

Notified by: **National IHR Focal Point, Australia**

07 October 2024

### Situation Overview

The Australian Department of Health and Aged Care has reported to WHO two distinct clusters of severe respiratory illness in Brisbane, Queensland, with no identified pathogen. As of October 8, a total of 36 confirmed hospitalizations have been reported, including elderly individuals in a nursing home outbreak and a separate family cluster involving children and a parent.

While investigations are ongoing, epidemiological links between the two clusters remain unconfirmed. Laboratory testing for common respiratory pathogens, including influenza, RSV, SARS-CoV-2, and bacterial pneumonia agents, has been negative. Genomic sequencing and advanced diagnostics are underway.

### Key Developments

#### Nursing Home Cluster (Kelvin Grove, Brisbane)

- First detected on September 26 at a long-term care facility.
- 21 elderly residents and 2 caregivers hospitalized, with pneumonia and respiratory distress.
- 9 additional residents and 1 caregiver admitted on October 5.
- Facility under strict isolation; contact tracing ongoing.

#### Family Cluster (Fairfield)

- First case: 4-year-old child admitted on September 26 with respiratory distress.

- Mother developed severe symptoms on September 27, hospitalized at Princess Alexandra Hospital.
- 12-year-old sibling admitted on September 30 with atypical pneumonia; 15-year-old sibling also affected.
- 100 contacts identified and being monitored, mainly schoolmates.
- No travel history reported for the family.

## Current Public Health Actions

- Queensland Health and the Australian CDC are leading response efforts.
- Enhanced surveillance in hospitals, aged care facilities, and schools across Brisbane.
- Forensic and Scientific Services (FSS) is conducting in-depth pathogen analysis.
- Precautionary infection control measures were reinforced at affected hospitals and care facilities.
- No international travel advisory at this time, but airports and border agencies have been alerted.

## Risk Assessment

- Public Health Risk: Moderate to High (Pending Identification of Pathogen).
- Potential for Global Spread: Unknown. No confirmed travel-related cases at this stage.
- Severity: Multiple hospitalizations, including among younger individuals and the elderly.
- Response Level: WHO is monitoring closely. No PHEIC declared at this time.

## Recommendations for WHO Member States

- Enhanced surveillance for severe acute respiratory infections (SARI) and pneumonia cases in hospitals, particularly among vulnerable populations.
- Strengthened laboratory testing and genomic sequencing for unidentified respiratory illnesses.
- Review of international case reports for potential matching clusters.
- Preparedness for possible WHO Emergency Committee meeting should the situation escalate.

## Next Steps & Further Information

- WHO Western Pacific Regional Office (WPRO) in Manila is coordinating with Australian health authorities for real-time updates.
- Laboratories worldwide are encouraged to share any comparable unexplained respiratory illness case data.
- Further updates will be provided as test results and epidemiological investigations progress.

*For further details, contact: WHO IHR Emergency Team at [email contact].*